

Social Psychology 2



Interpersonal Relationships

Lecture 14
Summer 2026
Dr. McPhee

Learning Objectives

By the end of class today, students should be able to...

- ...define **reproduction**, and discuss how humans are unique in their approach to reproduction.
- ...describe differences in **mate selectivity** between sexes and genders.
- ... discuss three types of **romantic attraction**, including:
 - **Physical Attraction**
 - **Situational Attraction**
 - **Psychological Attraction**
- ...discuss human susceptibility to **social influence** and review the **hedonic** and **approval** motives.
- ...define **aggression**.
 - ...illustrate the **Frustration–Aggression Hypothesis** with an example.
 - ...discuss some biological and cultural factors that contribute to levels of aggression.
- ...define **prosocial behaviours**, and **altruism**.
 - ...understand the difference between altruism displayed due **to kinship selection** versus **reciprocal altruism**.
- ...define **cooperation**.
 - ...explain how cooperation relates to **group cognition** and explain how group cognition can affect our attitudes and behaviours.

Reproduction

- **Reproduction** is one way in which almost all animals are social.
- Again, humans are especially social in this regard.
- We will cover most of this in Module 17!



Mate Selectivity



The picture highlights the differences in mate selectivity across sexes.

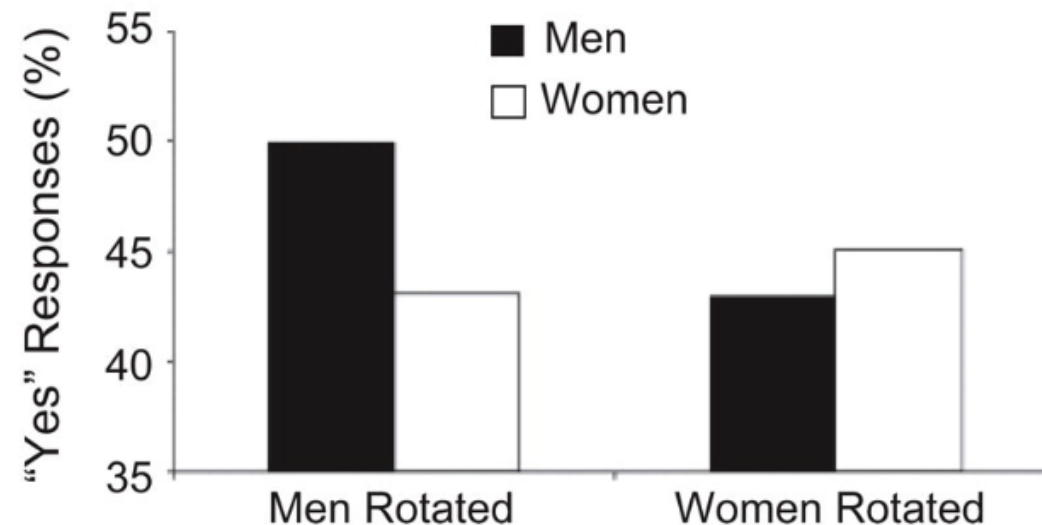
- Humans are quite selective in terms of their sexual partners.
 - Females (sex) tend to be more selective than males are.
 - Why are there differences in **mate selectivity**?
 - Biological Factors:
 - Sperm Count versus Egg Count.
 - Physical Requirements/Changes that Accompany Pregnancy.
 - Males can keep reproducing constantly.
 - In contrast, females can only reproduce approximately once a year.

Mate Selectivity



Finkel & Eastwick (2009) used a simulated speed dating event in their research on courtship rituals.

- Why are there differences in **mate selectivity** (continued)?
 - Women (gender) may also be more selective than men because of societal pressure.
 - Reputational costs of promiscuity (“slut shaming”).
 - Women are approached more often and therefore, have more options available to them.
 - Cultural **courtship rituals** can affect this selectivity.



The number of participants who said “yes” to a potential mate as a function of whether the men or women rotated seats.

Interpersonal Attraction



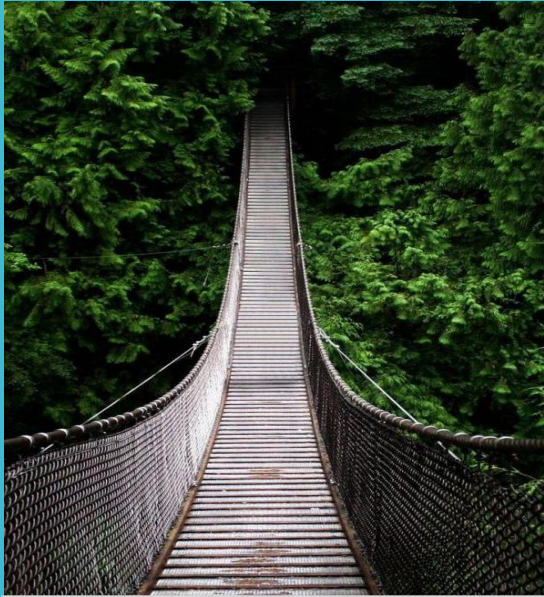
- We choose potential sexual partners based on a number of factors.
- Factors that increase liking:
 - Physical Attractiveness, Proximity, and Similarity
- **Mere Exposure Effect:**
 - Familiarity breeds content.
- We like those who like us.
- Three types of **romantic attraction**:
 1. **Physical Attraction**
 2. **Situational Attraction**
 3. **Psychological Attraction**

1. Physical Attraction



- One of the first things we notice about a social partner (sexual or otherwise) is their **physical attraction**.
- This factor is also the most powerful, at first.
 - Walster and colleagues (1966) measured university students' perceptions of potential sexual partners whom they had met only once.
 - Physical attraction was the only attribute that accurately predicted whether they felt attracted to the other individual.
- Beauty is universally beneficial but beauty is not universal.
 - Being beautiful carries benefits in all cultures.
 - But not all cultures define beauty in the same ways.
- For example: Some cultures value overweight partners over normal-weight partners.

2. Situational Attraction



The Capilano Bridge.

- Physical attraction is often the first thing that we notice, but other factors play a role as well.
- Perhaps the greatest factor in our attraction to each other is simply **situational attraction**.
- We try hard to like the people that we are around, because we have to live with them!
- Recall, the **mere exposure effect**.
 - Simply spending time with someone may make you more attracted to him/her/them!
- This is especially true if we spend time together in psychologically arousing situations.
 - Example: The Capilano Bridge experiment!

3. Psychological Attraction



- In addition to physical and situational factors, **psychological attraction** is also important.
- We are more attracted to people who are similar to ourselves:
 - Level of Education, Religion, SES, Personality.

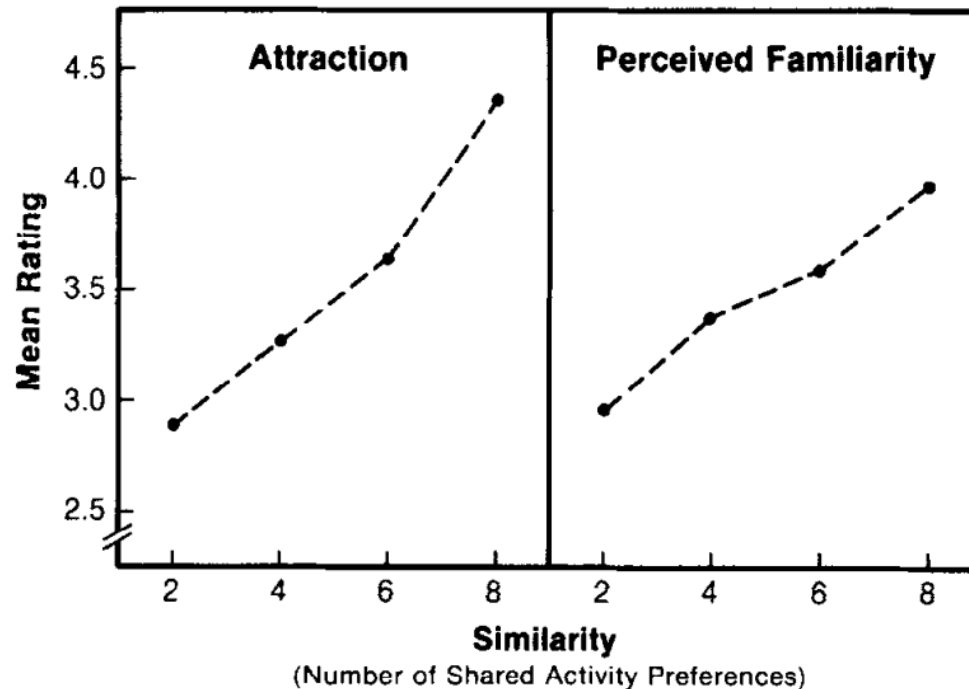


FIG. 2. Effects of similarity on perceived familiarity and attraction.

Social Influence

- Speaking of relationships, one aspect of social psychology that we all engage in is (the attempt) to control other individuals.
- We call this control **social influence**.
- We are all susceptible to social influence.
- We will explore two motivations for this susceptibility:
 - **Hedonic Motivation**
 - **Approval Motivation**



Hedonic Motivation

- Remember the hedonic principle from Module 11?
 - **Hedonic Principle:** “All motivation is basically rooted in approach to pleasure and avoidance of pain.”
- Appealing to the hedonic principle is one of the most powerful ways to control others.
 - E.g., Why do we build romantic relationships?
 - Relationships → Feelings of Love/Acceptance or Sexual Satisfaction → Approach to Pleasure
 - E.g., Why don't we speed while driving?
 - Speeding → Caught by Police Officer → Given Ticket and Fined → Lose Money and Possibly Serve Jail Sentence → Pain (We want to avoid this!).



Hedonic Motivation

- But appealing to the hedonic principle with rewards can backfire.
- In a study with children, Lepper and colleagues (1973) divided subjects into two groups:
 - Children who were given a prize for drawing with markers.
 - Children who were allowed to draw but not given a prize.
- The next day, children who were given no prize continued to be interested in the markers.
- Children who were given a prize were less likely to draw with the markers.
- Why?



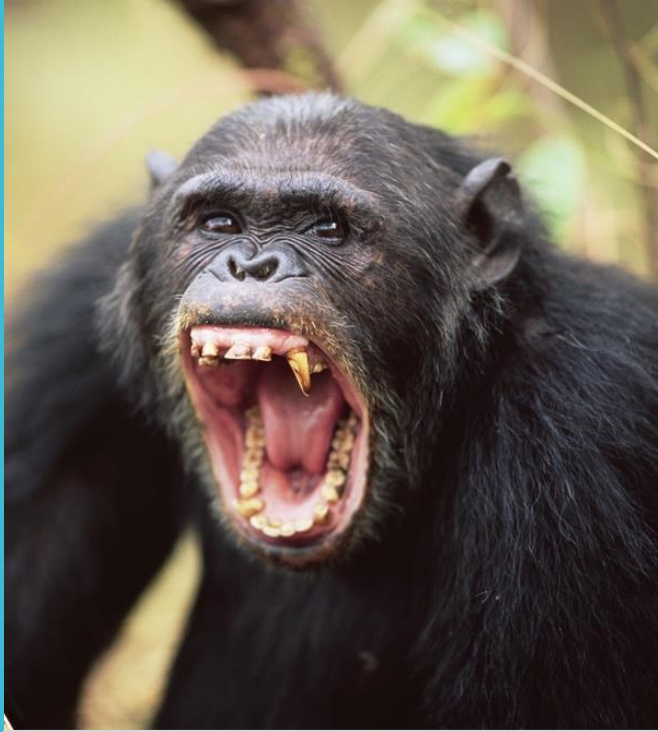
Approval Motivation



- Another powerful mechanism to control other individuals is to appeal to their desire for **approval**.
- We are motivated to have others like us and approve of us.
- One way in which approval motivates our actions is by our adherence to **norms**.
 - What is the **norm** for behaviour on a date? In a movie theatre? At a restaurant?
- We obey these norms religiously because they make us more likeable.
- This is the **normative influence**.
- This normative influence often causes us to **conform** to the behaviour of others (recall Asch's conformity study!).



Aggression



Picture of an animal behaving aggressively.

- **Aggression** is behaviour with the purpose of harming another.
- It can sometimes be good.
- Types of aggression:
 1. **Instrumental aggression** is when violent behaviour occurs on purpose to achieve a goal (e.g., to obtain food).
 2. **Hostile aggression** is when violent behaviour occurs for the sole purpose of inflicting harm on another (e.g., in response to a threat).

Why Aggress?

- One hypothesis for why humans and other animals aggress is the **Frustration-Aggression Hypothesis**.
 - Animals aggress when their desires are frustrated.
 - E.g., Organism A frustrates Organism B's desire for food, so Organism B attacks Organism A.
- Some researchers argue that this hypothesis is too narrow.
- Humans sometimes aggress when they are feeling negative emotional states (even if their desires aren't being frustrated).



Picture of human beings behaving aggressively.

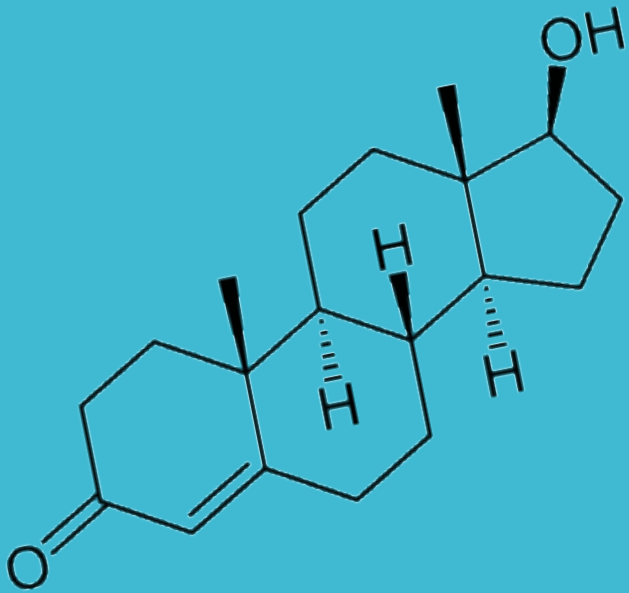
Individual Differences in Aggression



Picture of a man displaying aggression.

- Although all humans aggress, some humans are more likely than others to do so.
- What factors make a human more likely to aggress?
 - Biological Factors
 - Genetics (accounts for 60% of variability)
 - Sex
 - Testosterone Levels
 - Environmental Factors
 - Culture
 - Societal Expectations

Biology and Aggression



Picture of a testosterone molecule.

- The greatest predictors of an individual's level of aggression are...
 - Immediate family members who are aggressive.
 - Sex.
- Males are significantly more aggressive than females.
 - Testosterone appears to be implicated.
 - Younger men with more testosterone = more aggressive.
 - Women with more testosterone = more aggressive.
- Why does testosterone make people more aggressive?
 - Testosterone does not appear to make people more aggressive across all situations.
 - But it appears to decrease individuals' threat assessments when in danger.
 - People with more testosterone may be less afraid of retaliation.

Environment and Aggression

- Aggression is evolutionarily adaptive.
- So will humans always be aggressive?
- Aggression has decreased significantly in the last century.
 - Fewer wars, fewer murders, etc.
 - Why?
- So aggression is not inevitable.
 - Certain cultures are far more (or less) violent than others.
 - Why?
 - Some evidence suggests scarcity of resources.
 - Recall, the **Frustration-Aggression Hypothesis**!

Prosocial Behaviours/ Altruism



Picture of altruistic
behaviour.

- What are **prosocial behaviours**?
- What is **altruism**?
- What does **altruism** look like in other non-human animals?
 - **Kinship Selection**—extending "altruistic" behaviour to related individuals, thus increasing the likelihood that one's genetic material will be passed on.
 - **Reciprocal Altruism**—extending "altruistic" behaviour with the expectation that the favour will be returned.
- Are there true forms of altruism?
 - Can humans truly be altruistic?
 - If so, we may be alone in the animal kingdom in exhibiting altruism.

Cooperation

- **Cooperation** is behaviour by two or more individuals that leads to mutual benefit.
- Instead of aggression, cooperation is another way of solving our problem of scarcity of resources.
- Cooperation helps us to acquire and protect our resources.
 - So it is adaptive for our survival.
- Why don't we just cooperate all the time?
 - Cooperation is risky!
 - Resources are (were) scarce!



Group Cognition



Picture of “in-group” versus “out-group”.

- Because cooperation is risky and resources can be scarce, we often choose to cooperate in **groups**.
- Groups are collections of people that have something in common that distinguishes them from others.
 - Examples: families, teams, religions, ethnicities, nations.
 - Groups can be elicited spontaneously and arbitrarily (e.g., shirt colour).
- Individuals who are part of your group are your “in-group”, while people who are not part of your group are the “out-group”.
- We tend to have **positive prejudices** and exhibit **positive discrimination** toward members of our in-group.

Groups, Attitudes & Behaviours: Prejudice

- **Prejudice** is a negative attitude associated with hate.
- Can be based on any common characteristic: gender, ethnicity, religion, country of origin, skin color, sexual preference, body size, etc.
- Can transcend individual groups and be directed at anyone with that characteristic.
- Learned from parents, peers, first-hand experience, and vicarious conditioning.

Groups, Attitudes & Behaviours: Discrimination

- **Discrimination** is adverse behaviours directed at groups toward which one holds negative and prejudicial beliefs.
- Acting on prejudice.
- Working to harm those from one group or with a specific, disliked characteristic.



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